

The Sunken Halls of Tidewatch

A D&D 5th Edition Dungeon Crawl for Characters Level 3-5

Adventure Length: 4-6 sessions

Party Size: 4-6 characters

Adventure Type: Dungeon Crawler / Exploration

Themes: Underwater exploration, elemental magic, redemption

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Adventure Background

Beneath the waves off the coast of Saltmarsh lies the ruins of Tidewatch Keep, a fortress that was swallowed by the sea during a great magical storm fifty years ago. Once the proud stronghold of the Order of the Coral Throne, it served as both a naval base and a repository for aquatic magical research. When the storm hit, the keep's protective barriers failed catastrophically, dragging the entire structure into the depths along with its treasures and secrets.

Recent underwater tremors have shifted the sea floor, partially exposing the keep's upper levels during low tide and creating air pockets within its flooded halls. Fishermen report strange lights glowing beneath the waves, and several vessels have been attacked by creatures that should not exist in these waters. The party has been hired to investigate the ruins, recover any valuable artifacts, and put an end to whatever menace has awakened in the depths.

This underwater dungeon presents unique challenges: flooded passages that require swimming or magical aid, air-breathing creatures adapted to aquatic life, and the constant threat of drowning.

The party must manage their resources carefully while exploring chambers filled with corrupted sea life, animated coral constructs, and the undead remnants of the keep's former defenders.

Central Mystery: The keep's research into merging land and sea magic created an unstable planar rift to the Elemental Plane of Water. The rift has been slowly expanding, corrupting local sea life and creating hybrid creatures. The party must either seal the rift or destroy the artifact keeping it open before it grows large enough to flood the entire coastal region.

The Order of the Coral Throne

The Order of the Coral Throne was founded three centuries ago by Sir Nereon Tidecaller, a paladin who received visions from Istishia, the Water Lord. The Order served as both protectors of the coastal regions and researchers into the mysteries of elemental water magic. Unlike traditional knightly orders focused solely on martial prowess, the Coral Throne attracted scholars, druids, and clerics alongside paladins and fighters.

The Order's Philosophy: They believed that the boundary between land and sea was artificial, and that true mastery came from understanding both realms. Their ultimate goal was to create magic that could allow settlements to exist both above and below water, expanding civilization into the ocean depths.

Key Figures of the Order:

- **Sir Nereon Tidecaller** (Founder): His preserved body lies in the deepest vault, transformed into a coral-encrusted revenant
- **Archmage Thalassa Deepcurrent** (Chief Researcher): Her spirit is bound to the planar rift, slowly becoming an elemental entity
- **Captain Marina Stormborn** (Military Commander): Now leads the drowned garrison as a death knight
- **Brother Pelagic** (Head Librarian): His ghost haunts the archives, still trying to complete his research

The Great Confluence

Fifty years ago, the Order's experiments reached a critical juncture. They had successfully opened a stable portal to the Elemental Plane of Water, intending to harvest pure elemental energy for their magical research. However, they underestimated the plane's chaotic nature.

What Went Wrong: During a ritual to expand the portal, multiple elemental lords attempted to claim the gateway simultaneously. Their conflict created massive instabilities that manifested as the Great Confluence - a storm that existed in both the material plane and the elemental plane simultaneously.

The Disaster: The storm didn't just sink the keep; it partially merged it with a section of the Elemental Plane of Water. This is why the ruins exhibit impossible geometry in some areas and

why creatures from that plane continue to emerge. The magical research didn't simply fail - it created a permanent weak point between the planes.

Adventure Hooks

- **Coastal Commission:** The port authority of Saltmarsh offers 500 gold pieces to investigate the underwater disturbances threatening shipping lanes
 - **Scholarly Interest:** A sage seeks the Order's research notes on elemental magic, believed to contain the key to preventing coastal flooding
 - **Personal Vendetta:** A character has family history with the Order of the Coral Throne or lost someone in the original disaster
 - **Treasure Hunting:** Rumors speak of the Order's treasury, protected by magical seals that might have survived the flooding
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Underwater Rules and Environmental Challenges

Swimming and Movement

- **Swimming Speed:** Half normal speed unless character has swim speed
- **Breath Holding:** Constitution modifier + 1 minutes before suffocation begins
- **Armor Penalties:** Heavy armor imposes disadvantage on swimming checks
- **Three-Dimensional Combat:** Creatures can attack from above and below

Modified Combat Mechanics

- **Weapon Restrictions:** Slashing weapons have disadvantage underwater
- **Fire Immunity:** Fire damage impossible unless magical
- **Lightning Conductivity:** Lightning damage affects all creatures within 5 feet
- **Spell Modifications:** Some spells function differently underwater

Environmental Hazards

- **Decompression:** Rapid ascent causes 1d6 damage per 30 feet
- **Water Pressure:** Disadvantage on some actions at depths below 100 feet
- **Limited Visibility:** Perception checks beyond 60 feet have disadvantage
- **Current Effects:** Strong currents impose movement restrictions

Approaching Tidewatch Keep

The Underwater Journey: *The ruins of Tidewatch Keep rise from the sea floor like a drowned mountain, its coral-encrusted towers visible through thirty feet of clear blue water. Kelp forests*

sway around the structure's base, while schools of fish dart between the broken battlements. At the keep's highest point, an air pocket has formed where the great hall's dome has cracked, allowing a pocket of breathable air to remain trapped within.

Entry Points:

- **The Great Hall Dome:** Air pocket allows surface entry but requires 30-foot swim down
 - **Collapsed Wall:** Direct entry to flooded areas but fully submerged
 - **Kelp Forest Entrance:** Concealed but guarded by aggressive sea life
 - **Drainage Tunnels:** Narrow passages that may or may not contain air
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Level 1: The Flooded Battlements

Room 1A: The Guard Tower

This circular chamber rises forty feet to a partially collapsed roof. The lower twenty feet are flooded, while the upper portion contains a pocket of stale but breathable air. Rusty weapons and waterlogged equipment float near the surface, and barnacles have claimed every submerged surface.

Environmental Features:

- **Air Pocket:** Upper 20 feet breathable but stale (Constitution save DC 12 after 10 minutes or gain exhaustion)
- **Floating Debris:** Provides partial cover but shifts position
- **Weak Floor:** Areas marked by excessive coral growth may collapse (Investigation DC 15 to detect)
- **Tide Pools:** Small pockets of trapped sea water containing tiny aggressive creatures

Encounters:

Reef Shark *Medium beast, unaligned*

- **Armor Class** 12 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 22 (4d8 + 4)
- **Speed** 0 ft., swim 40 ft.
- **STR** 14 (+2) **DEX** 13 (+1) **CON** 13 (+1) **INT** 1 (-5) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 4 (-3)
- **Skills** Perception +2
- **Senses** blindsight 30 ft., passive Perception 12
- **Languages** —
- **Challenge** 1/2 (100 XP)

Blood Frenzy. The shark has advantage on melee attack rolls against any creature that doesn't have all its hit points. **Water Breathing.** The shark can breathe only underwater.

Actions *Bite. Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) piercing damage.

Giant Octopus (appears if combat lasts more than 3 rounds) *Large beast, unaligned*

- **Armor Class** 11
- **Hit Points** 52 (8d10 + 8)
- **Speed** 10 ft., swim 60 ft.
- **STR** 17 (+3) **DEX** 13 (+1) **CON** 13 (+1) **INT** 4 (-3) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 4 (-3)
- **Skills** Perception +4, Stealth +5
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14
- **Languages** —
- **Challenge** 1 (200 XP)

Hold Breath. While out of water, the octopus can hold its breath for 1 hour. **Underwater Camouflage.** The octopus has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made while underwater. **Water Breathing.** The octopus can breathe only underwater.

Actions *Tentacles. Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (2d6 + 3) bludgeoning damage. If the target is a creature, it is grappled (escape DC 16). Until this grapple ends, the target is restrained, and the octopus can't use its tentacles on another target.

Ink Cloud (Recharges after a Short or Long Rest). A 20-foot-radius cloud of ink extends all around the octopus if it is underwater. The area is heavily obscured for 1 minute, although a significant current can disperse the ink. After releasing the ink, the octopus can use the Dash action as a bonus action.

Encounter: 3 Reef Sharks, 1 Giant Octopus

Treasure:

- Waterproof Scroll Case containing *Water Breathing* spell scroll
- 50 gp in corroded coins scattered on the floor
- Masterwork Trident (+1 to attack rolls)

Room 1B: The Armory

Weapon racks line the walls of this rectangular chamber, most of their contents rusted beyond use. However, some magical weapons still gleam with protective enchantments, and a large chest sits sealed in one corner.

Environmental Features:

- **Completely Flooded:** No air pocket, requires water breathing
- **Strong Current:** Flows through broken window, imposes movement restrictions
- **Unstable Shelving:** Attack rolls or sudden movements may cause collapses

Encounters:

Coral Skeleton *Medium undead, lawful evil*

- **Armor Class** 14 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 19 (3d8 + 6)
- **Speed** 30 ft., swim 30 ft.
- **STR** 10 (+0) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 15 (+2) **INT** 6 (-2) **WIS** 8 (-1) **CHA** 5 (-3)
- **Damage Vulnerabilities** bludgeoning
- **Damage Resistances** cold
- **Damage Immunities** poison
- **Condition Immunities** exhaustion, poisoned
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 9
- **Languages** understands all languages it spoke in life but can't speak
- **Challenge** 1/2 (100 XP)

Coral Growth. When the skeleton takes damage, razor-sharp coral grows from the wound. The next creature that hits the skeleton with a melee attack before the end of the skeleton's next turn takes 2 (1d4) slashing damage. **Water Breathing.** The skeleton can breathe air and water.

Actions **Coral Cutlass.** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) slashing damage plus 2 (1d4) piercing damage from coral shards.

Shortbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 80/320 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Encounter: 4 Coral Skeletons

Treasure:

- Locked Chest (Thieves' Tools DC 15): Contains 200 gp, 3 pearls worth 50 gp each
- +1 Scimitar still sharp despite submersion
- Cloak of the Manta Ray
- Potion of Water Breathing (2 doses)

Room 1C: The Drowned Chapel

Once a place of worship for sea-going knights, this chamber now hosts corrupted religious ceremonies. Kelp hangs like tattered banners from the vaulted ceiling, and barnacles have claimed the altar. A faint, unholy light emanates from corrupted religious symbols.

Environmental Features:

- **Partially Flooded:** Lower 15 feet flooded, upper area has stale air
- **Corrupted Altar:** Radiates unholy energy, causes disadvantage on death saves within 10 feet

- **Kelp Curtains:** Provide concealment but may hide enemies
- **Unstable Pews:** Old wooden benches that collapse if used for cover

Encounters:

Drowned Devotee *Medium undead, chaotic evil*

- **Armor Class** 12
- **Hit Points** 16 (3d8 + 3)
- **Speed** 20 ft., swim 40 ft.
- **STR** 13 (+1) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 12 (+1) **INT** 7 (-2) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 8 (-1)
- **Damage Resistances** cold
- **Damage Immunities** poison
- **Condition Immunities** poisoned
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10
- **Languages** understands Common but speaks only in gurgles
- **Challenge** 1/4 (50 XP)

Waterlogged. The devotee moves at half speed on land but has advantage on Stealth checks while underwater. **Final Prayer.** When the devotee is reduced to 0 hit points, it speaks a final prayer. All creatures within 15 feet must make a DC 11 Wisdom saving throw or be frightened until the end of their next turn.

Actions **Rotting Touch.** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) necrotic damage, and the target must make a DC 11 Constitution saving throw or contract a disease. Until the disease is cured, the target's hit point maximum decreases by 1d4 every 24 hours.

Corrupted Priest *Medium undead, neutral evil*

- **Armor Class** 13 (Chain Shirt)
- **Hit Points** 27 (5d8 + 5)
- **Speed** 25 ft., swim 30 ft.
- **STR** 10 (+0) **DEX** 10 (+0) **CON** 12 (+1) **INT** 13 (+1) **WIS** 16 (+3) **CHA** 13 (+1)
- **Skills** Medicine +7, Persuasion +3, Religion +4
- **Damage Resistances** necrotic
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13
- **Languages** Common, Celestial
- **Challenge** 2 (450 XP)

Spellcasting. The priest is a 3rd-level spellcaster. Its spellcasting ability is Wisdom (spell save DC 13, +5 to hit with spell attacks). It has the following cleric spells prepared:

- **Cantrips (at will):** *light, sacred flame, thaumaturgy*
- **1st level (4 slots):** *bane, command, inflict wounds*
- **2nd level (2 slots):** *hold person, spiritual weapon*

Actions *Coral Mace. Melee Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage plus 3 (1d6) piercing damage from coral spikes.

Encounter: 4 Drowned Devotees, 1 Corrupted Priest

Treasure:

- Unholy Symbol of a corrupted sea deity (worth 25 gp, cursed)
- Potion of Poison disguised as holy water
- Scroll of Lesser Restoration
- Ceremonial Dagger (+1 dagger with wave motifs)

Room 1D: The Kelp Forest Entrance

A natural cave opening leads into dense underwater kelp forests. The passage is barely wide enough for a single person, and the kelp sways hypnotically in the current. Strange phosphorescent creatures drift between the fronds.

Environmental Features:

- **Completely Submerged:** No air, requires water breathing or held breath
- **Dense Kelp:** Difficult terrain, provides heavy concealment
- **Bioluminescence:** Kelp glows when disturbed, revealing movement
- **Strong Current:** Flows toward deeper areas, requires Strength checks to resist

Encounters:

Giant Seahorse *Large beast, neutral*

- **Armor Class** 13 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 16 (3d10)
- **Speed** 0 ft., swim 40 ft.
- **STR** 12 (+1) **DEX** 15 (+2) **CON** 11 (+0) **INT** 2 (-4) **WIS** 12 (+1) **CHA** 5 (-3)
- **Senses** passive Perception 11
- **Languages** —
- **Challenge** 1/2 (100 XP)

Charge. If the seahorse moves at least 20 feet straight toward a target and then hits it with a ram attack on the same turn, the target takes an extra 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage. If the target is a creature, it must succeed on a DC 11 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone. **Water Breathing.** The seahorse can breathe only underwater.

Actions *Ram. Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d10 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

Kelp Blight *Medium plant, neutral evil*

- **Armor Class** 12 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 10 ft., swim 30 ft.
- **STR** 13 (+1) **DEX** 8 (-1) **CON** 13 (+1) **INT** 4 (-3) **WIS** 8 (-1) **CHA** 3 (-4)
- **Condition Immunities** blinded, deafened
- **Senses** blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 9
- **Languages** understands Common but can't speak
- **Challenge** 1/4 (50 XP)

False Appearance. While the blight remains motionless among kelp, it is indistinguishable from ordinary seaweed. **Underwater Camouflage.** The blight has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made while underwater among aquatic plants.

Actions ***Fronk Lash.** Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) bludgeoning damage, and if the target is a Medium or smaller creature, it must succeed on a DC 11 Strength saving throw or be grappled by kelp fronds (escape DC 11).

Encounter: 2 Giant Seahorses, 6 Kelp Blights

Treasure:

- Seahorse Whistle (summons giant seahorse mount for 1 hour, 1/day)
- Kelp Rope (50 feet, never rots, floats)
- Pearl of the Depths (worth 100 gp, glows underwater)

Room 1E: The Tide Pool Laboratories

Small chambers carved into the rock walls contain what were once magical research pools. Now they bubble with unknown chemicals and house aggressive creatures mutated by magical experimentation.

Environmental Features:

- **Ankle-Deep Water:** Slow movement, splashing alerts creatures
- **Chemical Pools:** Various colors, unknown effects if touched
- **Broken Glassware:** Difficult terrain, risk of cuts
- **Gas Vents:** Periodic releases of potentially harmful vapors

Encounters:

Mutated Crab *Small monstrosity, unaligned*

- **Armor Class** 15 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 13 (3d6 + 3)
- **Speed** 30 ft., swim 30 ft.
- **STR** 13 (+1) **DEX** 15 (+2) **CON** 13 (+1) **INT** 3 (-4) **WIS** 9 (-1) **CHA** 3 (-4)

- **Skills** Stealth +4
- **Senses** blindsight 30 ft., passive Perception 9
- **Languages** —
- **Challenge** 1/2 (100 XP)

Amphibious. The crab can breathe air and water. **Magical Mutation.** The crab's claws crackle with residual magical energy. On a critical hit, the target must make a DC 12 Constitution saving throw or suffer a random magical effect for 1 minute (roll on wild magic table, GM's discretion for minor effects).

Actions **Claw.** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d4 + 2) bludgeoning damage plus 2 (1d4) force damage. If the target is a creature, it must succeed on a DC 11 Strength saving throw or be grappled (escape DC 11).

Experimental Ooze *Large ooze, unaligned*

- **Armor Class** 7
- **Hit Points** 45 (7d10 + 7)
- **Speed** 15 ft., swim 15 ft.
- **STR** 14 (+2) **DEX** 5 (-3) **CON** 12 (+1) **INT** 1 (-5) **WIS** 6 (-2) **CHA** 1 (-5)
- **Damage Resistances** acid, cold, fire
- **Condition Immunities** blinded, charmed, deafened, exhaustion, frightened, prone
- **Senses** blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 8
- **Languages** —
- **Challenge** 2 (450 XP)

Amorphous. The ooze can move through a space as narrow as 1 inch wide without squeezing.

Variable Chemistry. At the start of each of its turns, the ooze changes its damage type. Roll a d4: 1 = acid, 2 = cold, 3 = fire, 4 = lightning. Its attacks deal this damage type until its next turn.

Split. When an ooze that is Medium or larger is subjected to lightning or slashing damage, it splits into two new oozes if it has at least 10 hit points. Each new ooze has hit points equal to half the original ooze's, rounded down. New oozes are one size smaller than the original ooze.

Actions **Pseudopod.** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) bludgeoning damage plus 4 (1d8) damage of the ooze's current type (see Variable Chemistry).

Encounter: 3 Mutated Crabs, 1 Experimental Ooze

Treasure:

- Experimental Notes (worth 50 gp to scholars, provide advantage on next Arcana check)
 - Vial of Universal Solvent (destroys any non-magical material)
 - Ring of Chemical Resistance (resistance to acid damage)
 - Alchemist's Fire (3 vials, waterproofed)
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Level 2: The Scholarly Depths

Room 2A: The Flooded Archives

Massive stone shelves stretch from floor to ceiling, filled with waterlogged tomes and scrolls sealed in magical containers. Some books float freely, their pages fluttering like underwater birds. Preservation spells have kept many texts intact, but others have become homes for sea anemones and coral growths.

Environmental Features:

- **Magical Preservation:** Some areas have air pockets maintained by failing enchantments
- **Floating Books:** Provide cover but may contain hostile creatures
- **Knowledge Traps:** Some books release magical effects when opened
- **Scholar's Ghost:** Brother Pelagic manifests when anyone attempts to read the research

Key Research Notes Found Here:

- "Principles of Aquatic Architecture" - details on waterproof construction
- "Elemental Binding Theory" - crucial for understanding the planar rift
- "Physiological Adaptations to Underwater Life" - explains the mutated creatures
- "The Confluence Prophecy" - warnings about the disaster, written months before it occurred

Encounters:

Brother Pelagic's Ghost *Medium undead, neutral good*

- **Armor Class** 11
- **Hit Points** 45 (10d8)
- **Speed** 0 ft., fly 40 ft. (hover)
- **STR** 7 (-2) **DEX** 13 (+1) **CON** 10 (+0) **INT** 16 (+3) **WIS** 14 (+2) **CHA** 16 (+3)
- **Damage Resistances** acid, cold, fire, lightning, thunder; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
- **Damage Immunities** necrotic, poison
- **Condition Immunities** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 12
- **Languages** Common, Celestial, Aquan
- **Challenge** 4 (1,100 XP)

Ethereal Sight. The ghost can see 60 feet into the Ethereal Plane when it is on the Material Plane, and vice versa. **Incorporeal Movement.** The ghost can move through other creatures and objects as if they were difficult terrain. It takes 5 (1d10) force damage if it ends its turn inside an object. **Scholar's Obsession.** The ghost is compelled to share knowledge. If approached peacefully and asked about the Order's research, it will not attack unless threatened.

Actions *Withering Touch.* *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 17 (4d6 + 3) necrotic damage.

Etherealness. The ghost enters the Ethereal Plane from the Material Plane, or vice versa. It is visible on the Material Plane while it is in the Border Ethereal, and vice versa, yet it can't affect or be affected by anything on the other plane.

Horrifying Visage. Each non-undead creature within 60 feet of the ghost that can see it must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or be frightened for 1 minute. If the save fails by 5 or more, the target also ages 1d4 × 10 years. A frightened target can repeat the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the frightened condition on itself on a success. If a target's saving throw is successful or the effect ends for it, the target is immune to this ghost's Horrifying Visage for the next 24 hours.

Possession (Recharge 6). One humanoid that the ghost can see within 5 feet of it must succeed on a DC 13 Charisma saving throw or be possessed by the ghost; the ghost then disappears, and the target is incapacitated and loses control of its body. The ghost now controls the body but doesn't deprive the target of awareness. The ghost can't be targeted by any attack, spell, or other effect, except ones that turn undead, and it retains its alignment, Intelligence, Wisdom, Charisma, and immunity to being charmed and frightened. It otherwise uses the possessed target's statistics, but doesn't gain access to the target's knowledge, class features, or proficiencies.

Animated Tome *Small construct, unaligned*

- **Armor Class** 12 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 18 (4d6 + 4)
- **Speed** 0 ft., fly 30 ft. (hover)
- **STR** 1 (-5) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 13 (+1) **INT** 14 (+2) **WIS** 13 (+1) **CHA** 1 (-5)
- **Damage Resistances** piercing, slashing
- **Damage Immunities** poison, psychic
- **Condition Immunities** blinded, charmed, deafened, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned
- **Senses** blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 11
- **Languages** understands Common but can't speak
- **Challenge** 1/4 (50 XP)

Antimagic Susceptibility. The tome is incapacitated while in the area of an antimagic field. If targeted by dispel magic, the tome must succeed on a Constitution saving throw against the caster's spell save DC or fall unconscious for 1 minute.

False Appearance. While the tome remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from a normal book.

Actions *Slam.* *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

Blinding Ink (Recharge 5-6). The tome releases a 15-foot cone of magical ink. Each creature in the area must succeed on a DC 12 Constitution saving throw or be blinded for 1 minute. A creature can repeat the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on itself on a success.

Encounter: 1 Brother Pelagic's Ghost, 6 Animated Tomes

Treasure:

- Complete research library worth 2,000 gp to scholars
- Spell Scroll: *Water Walk*
- Spell Scroll: *Control Water*
- Lore Book of Elemental Planes (+2 to Intelligence checks regarding elementals)

Room 2B: The Transformation Laboratory

Circular pools of various sizes are built into the floor, each once used for different experiments in biological adaptation. Skeletal remains of test subjects - both humanoid and sea creatures - are scattered throughout. Strange hybrid creatures lurk in the deeper pools.

Environmental Features:

- **Experimental Pools:** Various depths, some containing active magical effects
- **Specimen Tanks:** Glass containers with preserved creatures, some still alive
- **Alchemical Equipment:** Provides cover but may explode if damaged
- **Transformation Circle:** Central ritual area that enhances mutation effects

The Order's Experiments: They were attempting to create humans who could breathe underwater and sea creatures that could survive on land. Most experiments failed horribly, creating the aberrations that now infest the keep.

Active Experiments: Some pools still contain living subjects - transformed Order members who have been trapped in half-completed states for fifty years. They remember fragments of their former lives but are driven mad by their twisted forms.

Encounters:

Transformed Researcher *Medium monstrosity, chaotic neutral*

- **Armor Class** 13 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 52 (8d8 + 16)
- **Speed** 20 ft., swim 40 ft.
- **STR** 16 (+3) **DEX** 12 (+1) **CON** 15 (+2) **INT** 13 (+1) **WIS** 8 (-1) **CHA** 6 (-2)
- **Skills** Arcana +4, Medicine +2
- **Damage Resistances** cold
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 9

- **Languages** Common, Aquan (fragmented)
- **Challenge** 3 (700 XP)

Amphibious. The researcher can breathe air and water. **Fragmented Memory.** The researcher remembers pieces of its past life. On initiative count 20, it may attempt to communicate (Charisma check DC 15) or become enraged (+2 to attack and damage for 1 minute).

Experimental Instability. When the researcher takes 10 or more damage from a single attack, it must make a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or undergo a random mutation for 1 minute (GM's choice).

Actions Multiattack. The researcher makes two attacks: one with its claws and one with its bite.

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 8 (1d10 + 3) slashing damage.

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage plus 3 (1d6) acid damage.

Toxic Spit (Recharge 5-6). The researcher spits toxic bile in a 15-foot line that is 5 feet wide. Each creature in that line must make a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw, taking 10 (3d6) poison damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Aquatic Aberration *Large aberration, chaotic evil*

- **Armor Class** 14 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 68 (8d10 + 24)
- **Speed** 10 ft., swim 50 ft.
- **STR** 18 (+4) **DEX** 8 (-1) **CON** 16 (+3) **INT** 4 (-3) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 5 (-3)
- **Damage Resistances** acid, cold
- **Senses** darkvision 90 ft., passive Perception 10
- **Languages** —
- **Challenge** 4 (1,100 XP)

Aberrant Form. The creature's body constantly shifts and changes. At the start of each turn, roll a d4: 1 = gains resistance to bludgeoning damage, 2 = gains resistance to piercing damage, 3 = gains resistance to slashing damage, 4 = gains +10 ft. movement speed.

Water Breathing. The aberration can breathe only underwater.

Actions Multiattack. The aberration makes three attacks: two with its tentacles and one with its bite.

Tentacle. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* 8 (1d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage. If the target is a creature, it is grappled (escape DC 15).

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one grappled target. **Hit:** 13 (2d8 + 4) piercing damage.

Psychic Scream (Recharge 6). The aberration emits a terrible psychic wail. All creatures within 30 feet must make a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw, taking 14 (4d6) psychic damage and being stunned until the end of their next turn on a failed save, or half damage and not stunned on a success.

Encounter: 2 Transformed Researchers, 1 Aquatic Aberration

Treasure:

- Experimental Notes on Biological Mutation (worth 300 gp to the right buyer)
- Potion of Giant Size (underwater variant - works only while submerged)
- Vial of Transformation Reversal (can cure lycanthropy or similar conditions)
- Alchemical Equipment worth 150 gp

Room 2C: The Elemental Observatory

A domed chamber with massive crystal windows that once provided views of the surrounding ocean. Now, they show glimpses of the Elemental Plane of Water. Arcane apparatus lines the walls, and a great astrolabe in the center tracks elemental convergences.

Environmental Features:

- **Planar Windows:** Crystal panels showing the Elemental Plane of Water
- **Astrolabe:** Complex device that tracks elemental energies
- **Magical Equipment:** Provides bonuses to spellcasting but may overload
- **Planar Instability:** Random surges of elemental energy

The Observatory's Purpose: This room was used to monitor elemental activity and predict optimal times for magical rituals. The equipment still functions, providing crucial information about the planar rift's stability.

Current State: The crystal windows randomly show different locations in the Elemental Plane of Water, sometimes revealing the activities of elemental lords who are still interested in claiming the rift for themselves.

Encounters:

Water Elemental *Large elemental, neutral*

- **Armor Class** 14 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 114 (12d10 + 48)
- **Speed** 30 ft., swim 90 ft.
- **STR** 18 (+4) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 18 (+4) **INT** 5 (-3) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 8 (-1)

- **Damage Resistances** acid; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
- **Damage Immunities** poison
- **Condition Immunities** exhaustion, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained, unconscious
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Aquan
- **Challenge** 5 (1,800 XP)

Water Form. The elemental can enter a hostile creature's space and stop there. It can move through a space as narrow as 1 inch wide without squeezing.

Freeze. If the elemental takes cold damage, it partially freezes; its speed is reduced by 20 feet until the end of its next turn.

Actions Multiattack. The elemental makes two slam attacks.

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 13 (2d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage.

Whelm (Recharge 4-6). Each creature in the elemental's space must make a DC 15 Strength saving throw. On a failure, a target takes 13 (2d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage. If it is Large or smaller, it is also grappled (escape DC 14). Until this grapple ends, the target is restrained and unable to breathe unless it can breathe water. If the saving throw is successful, the target is pushed out of the elemental's space.

Planar Mephit *Small elemental, neutral evil*

- **Armor Class** 11
- **Hit Points** 21 (6d6)
- **Speed** 30 ft., fly 30 ft., swim 30 ft.
- **STR** 8 (-1) **DEX** 12 (+1) **CON** 10 (+0) **INT** 9 (-1) **WIS** 11 (+0) **CHA** 12 (+1)
- **Damage Immunities** poison
- **Condition Immunities** poisoned
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Aquan, Auran
- **Challenge** 1/2 (100 XP)

Death Burst. When the mephit dies, it explodes in a burst of planar energy. Each creature within 5 feet of it must succeed on a DC 11 Dexterity saving throw or take 4 (1d8) force damage.

False Appearance. While the mephit remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from an ordinary pool of water.

Actions Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 3 (1d4 + 1) slashing damage plus 2 (1d4) cold damage.

Steam Breath (Recharge 6). The mephitis exhales a 15-foot cone of scalding steam. Each creature in that area must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw, taking 4 (1d8) fire damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Encounter: 1 Water Elemental, 4 Planar Mephitis

Special Mechanics:

- **Astrolabe Operation:** A successful DC 15 Arcana check reveals the planar rift's current stability (unstable and growing)
- **Window Observation:** Watching the Elemental Plane provides advantage on final encounter knowledge checks
- **Elemental Surge:** Every 3 rounds, random elemental energy fills the room (all creatures make DC 13 Dexterity save or take 7 (2d6) damage of random elemental type)

Treasure:

- Astrolabe of Planar Tracking (reveals portals and rifts within 1 mile)
 - Crystal Lens of True Seeing (functions as *True Seeing* spell 1/day)
 - Scroll of *Plane Shift*
 - Elemental Essence (component worth 500 gp for closing the rift)
-

Level 3: The Vault of Tides

The Order's treasury wasn't just a storage room for gold - it was a carefully designed vault that used the ebb and flow of magical tides to power its defenses. The vault exists in a state of temporal flux, with some areas experiencing accelerated time while others are frozen in magical stasis.

The Tidal Vault Mechanism

The treasury opens and closes based on magical tides that occur every six hours. When "high tide" occurs, the vault floods completely but its defenses are at their weakest. During "low tide," the waters recede but ancient guardians activate.

Current Tide State (roll d6 when party arrives): 1-3: Low Tide - Guardians active, vault accessible 4-6: High Tide - Flooding, defenses weakened

Room 3A: The Antechamber of Currents

Swirling patterns of water flow through channels carved into the floor and walls, creating a mesmerizing display of hydraulic artistry. Ancient mechanisms control the flow, and the sound of rushing water echoes throughout the chamber.

Environmental Features:

- **Water Channels:** Provide difficult terrain but can be redirected
- **Pressure Plates:** Hidden triggers for vault mechanisms (Investigation DC 16)
- **Temporal Eddies:** Some areas experience time differently
- **Guardian Alcoves:** Contain dormant constructs during high tide

Encounters (Low Tide Only):

Coral Guardian *Large construct, unaligned*

- **Armor Class** 17 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 142 (15d10 + 60)
- **Speed** 20 ft., swim 30 ft.
- **STR** 20 (+5) **DEX** 8 (-1) **CON** 18 (+4) **INT** 6 (-2) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 1 (-5)
- **Damage Resistances** piercing, slashing from nonmagical attacks
- **Damage Immunities** poison, psychic
- **Condition Immunities** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10
- **Languages** understands Common and Aquan but can't speak
- **Challenge** 8 (3,900 XP)

Immutable Form. The guardian is immune to any spell or effect that would alter its form.

Magic Resistance. The guardian has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Regenerating Coral. At the start of its turn, the guardian regains 5 hit points if it has at least 1 hit point and is in contact with water.

Actions Multiattack. The guardian makes two slam attacks.

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 16 (2d10 + 5) bludgeoning damage plus 5 (1d10) piercing damage from coral spikes.

Coral Spear Volley (Recharge 5-6). The guardian launches coral spears in a 30-foot cone. Each creature in the area must make a DC 16 Dexterity saving throw, taking 22 (4d10) piercing damage on a failed save, or half as much on a success.

Tidal Automaton *Medium construct, neutral*

- **Armor Class** 16 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 58 (9d8 + 18)
- **Speed** 30 ft., swim 40 ft.
- **STR** 16 (+3) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 14 (+2) **INT** 8 (-1) **WIS** 12 (+1) **CHA** 6 (-2)
- **Damage Immunities** poison, psychic

- **Condition Immunities** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 11
- **Languages** understands Common and Aquan but can't speak
- **Challenge** 4 (1,100 XP)

Magic Weapons. The automaton's weapon attacks are magical.

Tidal Affinity. The automaton's movement speed increases by 10 feet when in or near water.

Actions Multiattack. The automaton makes two weapon attacks.

Trident. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) piercing damage, or 8 (1d10 + 3) piercing damage if used with two hands to make a melee attack.

Water Bolt. Ranged Spell Attack: +4 to hit, range 60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 9 (2d8) bludgeoning damage, and the target must make a DC 13 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

Encounter (Low Tide): 1 Coral Guardian, 3 Tidal Automatons **Encounter (High Tide):** Environmental hazards only (strong currents, pressure damage)

Treasure:

- Mechanism Control Rod (allows manual operation of vault tides)
- Coral Armor (+1 studded leather, provides swim speed of 30 ft.)
- Pearls of Tide Turning (can reverse current tidal state for 1 hour)

Room 3B: The Treasury Proper

Golden artifacts gleam despite fifty years underwater, protected by powerful preservation magic. Chests of various sizes line the walls, while a magnificent display case holds the Order's most precious relics.

Environmental Features:

- **Preservation Fields:** Magic maintains air pockets around valuable items
- **Trapped Chests:** Various magical and mechanical traps
- **Display Cases:** Reinforced containers requiring specific keys or passwords
- **Temporal Stasis:** Some treasures exist outside normal time flow

Treasure Vaults (require different methods to open):

Vault A - The Common Treasury

- Lock: Thieves' Tools DC 18
- Contents: 3,000 gp, 500 sp, various gems worth 1,500 gp total

- Trap: Flooding trap (DC 16 Investigation to detect, DC 16 Thieves' Tools to disarm)

Vault B - The Magical Arsenal

- Lock: Requires password in Aquan ("Tidal's blessing flows eternal")
- Contents: +1 Weapons (2), Potions of Water Breathing (6), Scroll of Control Weather
- Trap: Polymorph trap (DC 17 Wisdom save or become fish for 1 hour)

Vault C - The Sacred Relics

- Lock: Requires holy symbol of approved sea deity
- Contents: Coral Crown, Tidecaller's Trident, Ceremonial Robes of the Order
- Guardian: Spiritual Guardian (appears when vault is opened)

Primary Treasures:

- **The Coral Crown:** Headpiece that grants the wearer the ability to breathe water and command sea creatures (up to Challenge 2, once per day)
- **Tidecaller's Trident:** +2 trident that can cast *control water* once per day and *water walk* at will
- **Scrolls of the Deep:** Complete collection of the Order's magical research, worth 5,000 gp to scholars
- **Pearls of Planar Binding:** Three pearls that can be used to stabilize or close the planar rift
- **The Order's War Chest:** 5,000 gold pieces in various currencies, including 500 gp in rare underwater civilization coins

Encounters:

Spiritual Guardian *Medium celestial, lawful good*

- **Armor Class** 15 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 52 (8d8 + 16)
- **Speed** 30 ft., fly 60 ft.
- **STR** 16 (+3) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 15 (+2) **INT** 13 (+1) **WIS** 16 (+3) **CHA** 17 (+3)
- **Damage Resistances** radiant; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
- **Condition Immunities** charmed, exhaustion, frightened
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13
- **Languages** Common, Celestial, Aquan
- **Challenge** 5 (1,800 XP)

Divine Weapons. The guardian's weapon attacks are magical and deal an extra 1d8 radiant damage.

Judge of Worth. The guardian can sense the intentions of creatures. If approached by those seeking treasure for selfish gain, it attacks. If approached by those seeking to help others or undo the rift, it may negotiate.

Actions *Multiattack.* The guardian makes two radiant sword attacks.

Radiant Sword. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) slashing damage plus 4 (1d8) radiant damage.

Healing Touch (3/Day). The guardian touches another creature. The target magically regains 10 (2d8 + 1) hit points and is freed from any disease, poison, blindness, or deafness.

Divine Shield (Recharge 5-6). The guardian creates a protective barrier. Until the start of its next turn, the guardian and all allies within 10 feet have resistance to all damage.

Encounter: 1 Spiritual Guardian (only if vault opened with improper intentions)

Level 4: The Planar Rift Chamber

The chamber containing the planar rift defies normal physics. Water flows upward in impossible spirals, gravity shifts randomly, and the boundaries between the Material Plane and Elemental Plane of Water blur. At the chamber's center, a swirling vortex of pure elemental energy grows slowly but steadily.

Room 4A: The Convergence Antechamber

Reality begins to bend as you approach the planar rift. Streams of water flow in impossible directions, defying gravity. The air itself seems thick with elemental energy, and strange whispers in Aquan echo from nowhere and everywhere.

Environmental Features:

- **Gravity Shifts:** Gravity changes direction every 2d4 rounds
- **Elemental Currents:** Floating streams of water provide movement paths
- **Reality Distortion:** Spells have unpredictable effects (10% chance of wild magic surge)
- **Temporal Echoes:** Occasionally see glimpses of the chamber before the disaster

Encounters:

Elemental Rift Guardian *Huge elemental, chaotic neutral*

- **Armor Class** 16 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 172 (15d12 + 75)
- **Speed** 30 ft., fly 60 ft., swim 90 ft.

- **STR** 22 (+6) **DEX** 12 (+1) **CON** 20 (+5) **INT** 8 (-1) **WIS** 14 (+2) **CHA** 10 (+0)
- **Damage Resistances** acid, cold; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
- **Damage Immunities** poison
- **Condition Immunities** exhaustion, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 12
- **Languages** Aquan, Primordial
- **Challenge** 10 (5,900 XP)

Planar Instability. At the start of each turn, roll a d6. On a 1-2, the guardian gains resistance to all damage until its next turn. On a 5-6, all creatures within 30 feet take 7 (2d6) force damage.

Rift Affinity. While within 60 feet of the planar rift, the guardian regains 10 hit points at the start of its turn.

Actions Multiattack. The guardian makes three attacks: two slams and one rift blast.

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +10 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* 19 (2d12 + 6) bludgeoning damage.

Rift Blast. *Ranged Spell Attack:* +6 to hit, range 120 ft., one target. *Hit:* 16 (3d10) force damage, and the target must make a DC 17 Constitution saving throw or be teleported to a random location within 60 feet.

Planar Vortex (Recharge 5-6). The guardian creates a 20-foot radius vortex centered on a point within 60 feet. All creatures in the area must make a DC 17 Strength saving throw or be pulled 15 feet toward the center and take 22 (4d10) force damage. The vortex lasts until the start of the guardian's next turn.

Encounter: 1 Elemental Rift Guardian

Room 4B: The Rift Chamber

The heart of the catastrophe lies before you. A swirling vortex of pure elemental water energy dominates the center of the chamber, crackling with chaotic magic. Through its depths, you glimpse the infinite expanse of the Elemental Plane of Water. The rift pulses with each heartbeat, growing imperceptibly larger.

Environmental Features:

- **The Planar Rift:** 20-foot diameter vortex in the chamber's center
- **Chaotic Magic:** All spells have a 25% chance of wild magic effects
- **Planar Bleed:** Creatures from the Elemental Plane occasionally emerge
- **Unstable Footing:** Platforms of crystallized water provide uncertain paths

The Rift's Current State:

- **Size:** Currently 20 feet in diameter, growing by 1 foot per month
- **Effects:** Creates severe weather within 10 miles, spawns elemental creatures weekly
- **Future Threat:** If it reaches 100 feet in diameter, it will permanently merge a 50-mile radius with the Elemental Plane of Water

Final Encounters:

Thalassa Deepcurrent, Bound Archmage *Medium humanoid (human), chaotic neutral*

- **Armor Class** 17 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 99 (18d8 + 18)
- **Speed** 30 ft., fly 60 ft.
- **STR** 10 (+0) **DEX** 16 (+3) **CON** 12 (+1) **INT** 20 (+5) **WIS** 15 (+2) **CHA** 14 (+2)
- **Saving Throws** Int +11, Wis +8
- **Skills** Arcana +17, History +11, Investigation +11
- **Damage Resistances** cold; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
- **Damage Immunities** charmed, frightened
- **Senses** truesight 120 ft., passive Perception 12
- **Languages** Common, Aquan, Primordial
- **Challenge** 9 (5,000 XP)

Planar Binding. Thalassa exists partially in both planes simultaneously. She can see and interact with both the Material Plane and Elemental Plane of Water. When she takes damage, roll a d6: on a 1-2, the damage affects her elemental form instead and is halved.

Spellcasting. Thalassa is an 18th-level spellcaster. Her spellcasting ability is Intelligence (spell save DC 19, +11 to hit with spell attacks). She has the following wizard spells prepared:

- **Cantrips (at will):** *mage hand, minor illusion, prestidigitation, ray of frost*
- **1st level (4 slots):** *magic missile, shield*
- **2nd level (3 slots):** *misty step, web*
- **3rd level (3 slots):** *counterspell, fireball, water breathing*
- **4th level (3 slots):** *confusion, polymorph*
- **5th level (3 slots):** *cone of cold, wall of force*
- **6th level (1 slot):** *chain lightning, disintegrate*
- **7th level (1 slot):** *plane shift*
- **8th level (1 slot):** *mind blank*
- **9th level (1 slot):** *time stop*

Fractured Consciousness. At the start of each turn, roll a d4 to determine Thalassa's mental state:

1. Lucid - Acts normally, may provide helpful information
2. Confused - Attacks random targets

3. Panicked - Uses defensive spells and tries to flee
4. Elemental - Behaves like a water elemental

Actions *Elemental Bolt.* *Ranged Spell Attack:* +11 to hit, range 120 ft., one target. *Hit:* 18 (3d8 + 5) cold damage, and the target's speed is reduced by 10 feet until the end of their next turn.

Planar Rift Manipulation (Recharge 5-6). Thalassa attempts to control the rift's energy. Choose one:

- **Stabilize:** The rift's chaotic effects are suppressed for 1 minute
- **Destabilize:** All creatures within 60 feet make DC 19 Constitution saves or take 22 (4d10) force damage
- **Summon:** 1d4 water elementals emerge from the rift

Sir Nereon Tidecaller, Coral Revenant *Medium undead, lawful neutral*

- **Armor Class** 17 (Natural Armor)
- **Hit Points** 136 (16d8 + 64)
- **Speed** 30 ft., swim 40 ft.
- **STR** 18 (+4) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 18 (+4) **INT** 13 (+1) **WIS** 16 (+3) **CHA** 18 (+4)
- **Saving Throws** Str +10, Con +10, Wis +9, Cha +10
- **Damage Resistances** necrotic, psychic
- **Damage Immunities** poison
- **Condition Immunities** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, poisoned, stunned
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13
- **Languages** Common, Celestial, Aquan
- **Challenge** 11 (7,200 XP)

Regeneration. The revenant regains 10 hit points at the start of its turn. If the revenant takes fire or radiant damage, this trait doesn't function at the start of the revenant's next turn. The revenant dies only if it starts its turn with 0 hit points and doesn't regenerate.

Rejuvenation. When the revenant's body is destroyed, its soul lingers. After 24 hours, the soul inhabits and animates another humanoid corpse on the same plane of existence and regains all its hit points. While the soul is bodiless, a wish spell can be used to force the soul to go to the afterlife and not return.

Vengeful Tracker. The revenant knows the distance to and direction of any creature against which it seeks revenge, even if the creature and the revenant are on different planes of existence. If the creature being tracked by the revenant dies, the revenant knows.

Coral Encasement. Nereon's body is encased in living coral that provides natural armor and weapon enhancement. His attacks count as magical.

Actions *Multiattack.* The revenant makes two fist attacks or two weapon attacks.

Fist. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. ***Hit:*** 11 (2d6 + 4) bludgeoning damage. If the target is a creature against which the revenant has sworn vengeance, the target takes an extra 14 (4d6) bludgeoning damage.

Tidecaller's Trident. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +12 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. ***Hit:*** 11 (1d8 + 7) piercing damage, or 12 (1d10 + 7) piercing damage if used with two hands. The weapon deals an extra 1d8 cold damage.

Coral Spear Volley (Recharge 5-6). Nereon causes coral spears to erupt from the ground in a 30-foot radius centered on a point within 60 feet. Each creature in the area must make a DC 18 Dexterity saving throw, taking 26 (4d12) piercing damage on a failed save, or half as much on a success.

Vengeful Glare. The revenant targets one creature it can see within 30 feet of it. The target must make a DC 18 Wisdom saving throw. On a failure, the target is paralyzed until the revenant deals damage to it, or until the end of the revenant's next turn.

Encounter Sequence:

1. **Initial Contact:** Thalassa appears first, her consciousness fractured but potentially helpful
2. **The Test:** Nereon emerges to judge the party's worthiness and intentions
3. **Final Challenge:** If the party proves worthy, both NPCs may aid in closing the rift; if not, they become the final obstacles

Closing the Rift: Requires the Pearls of Planar Binding, knowledge from Thalassa's research, and a willing sacrifice of magical energy. The ritual takes 3 rounds during which the party must:

- Round 1: Place the Pearls around the rift (requires getting within 10 feet)
- Round 2: Recite the binding incantation (requires DC 20 Arcana check)
- Round 3: Channel magical energy (requires sacrificing spell slots totaling at least 15 levels, or a magical item worth 1,000+ gp)

During the ritual, the rift violently resists, spawning water elementals and creating dangerous magical surges.

NPCs and Major Encounters

Captain Marina Stormborn, Death Knight

Medium undead, chaotic evil

Once the Order's military commander, Marina was caught in the heart of the magical storm. She now exists as a death knight, her body encased in coral armor, commanding the skeletal remains of her soldiers.

- **Armor Class** 20 (Plate, Shield)
- **Hit Points** 180 (19d8 + 95)
- **Speed** 30 ft., swim 40 ft.
- **STR** 20 (+5) **DEX** 11 (+0) **CON** 20 (+5) **INT** 12 (+1) **WIS** 16 (+3) **CHA** 18 (+4)
- **Saving Throws** Dex +6, Wis +9, Cha +10
- **Damage Immunities** necrotic, poison
- **Condition Immunities** exhaustion, frightened, poisoned
- **Senses** darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 13
- **Languages** Common, Aquan
- **Challenge** 13 (10,000 XP)

Magic Resistance. Marina has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Marshal Undead. As a bonus action, Marina can target one undead creature she can see within 30 feet. The target can use its reaction to make one weapon attack.

Spellcasting. Marina is an 11th-level spellcaster. Her spellcasting ability is Charisma (spell save DC 18, +10 to hit with spell attacks). She has the following paladin spells prepared:

- **1st level (4 slots):** *command, compelled duel, searing smite*
- **2nd level (3 slots):** *hold person, magic weapon*
- **3rd level (3 slots):** *dispel magic, fireball*

Actions Multiattack. Marina makes three longsword attacks.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +11 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 9 (1d8 + 5) slashing damage, or 10 (1d10 + 5) slashing damage if used with two hands, plus 4 (1d8) necrotic damage.

Hellfire Orb (1/Day). Marina hurls a magical ball of fire that explodes at a point she can see within 120 feet. Each creature in a 20-foot-radius sphere centered on that point must make a DC 18 Dexterity saving throw. The sphere spreads around corners. A creature takes 35 (10d6) fire damage and 35 (10d6) necrotic damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Marina's Dilemma: She knows the rift must be closed but lacks the magical knowledge to do so safely. She might aid the party if they prove they can complete her failed mission, but she'll fight them if she suspects they'll make the situation worse.

Brother Pelagic's Research Notes

Found throughout the archives, these provide crucial information:

"The Confluence Prophecy": *"The waters shall rise not from storm nor tide, but from the breaking of barriers between what is and what flows eternal. When lords of the deep contest for dominion over our threshold, the very foundations of reality shall crack. Beware the twenty-first day of Ches, when the confluence reaches its peak - for on this day, our hubris shall drown us all."*

"Principles of Rift Stabilization": *"To seal a planar breach requires three elements: Anchor (material components from both planes), Focus (concentrated magical energy), and Will (a conscious sacrifice to power the binding). The Pearls of Planar Binding serve as the perfect anchor, having been bathed in both elemental water and material plane energies for centuries."*

"Biological Adaptation Studies": *"Our subjects show promising adaptation to aquatic environments, though the psychological strain remains concerning. Note: Subject 12 began speaking in Aquan despite never learning the language. Subject 15 claims to hear the whispers of elemental lords. Recommend reducing exposure duration in future trials."*

Treasure and Rewards

Major Treasure Items

The Coral Crown *Wondrous item, very rare (requires attunement)* While wearing this crown made of living coral, you gain the following benefits:

- You can breathe air and water
- You have a swimming speed equal to your walking speed
- Once per day, you can cast *speak with animals* to communicate with aquatic creatures
- Once per day, you can cast *animal friendship* on aquatic beasts of Challenge Rating 2 or lower

Tidecaller's Trident *Weapon (trident), very rare (requires attunement)* You gain a +2 bonus to attack and damage rolls made with this magic weapon. The trident has the following additional properties:

- **Control Water:** Once per day, you can cast *control water* (save DC 15)
- **Water Walk:** You can cast *water walk* at will
- **Aquatic Command:** The trident deals an extra 1d8 cold damage to creatures that are not native to aquatic environments

Cloak of the Manta Ray *Wondrous item, uncommon* While wearing this cloak with its hood up, you can breathe underwater, and you have a swimming speed of 60 feet. Pulling the hood up or down requires an action.

Pearls of Planar Binding *Wondrous item, legendary* These three pearls shimmer with inner light that shifts between the colors of deep ocean and crackling lightning. When used together in a ritual (requiring 10 minutes and a successful DC 20 Arcana check), they can:

- Seal a planar rift permanently
- Stabilize a planar rift for 1 year
- Create a controlled portal between planes (lasting 1 hour)

Monetary Rewards

Total Treasure Value: Approximately 15,000-20,000 gp worth of treasure, magical items, and currency

Individual Room Treasures:

- Level 1 Total: ~3,000 gp value
- Level 2 Total: ~4,500 gp value
- Level 3 Total: ~12,000 gp value
- Level 4 Total: Priceless research and major magical items

Experience Rewards

Combat Encounters: Standard XP as listed with each encounter

Story Milestones:

- Discovering the truth about the Order: 500 XP per character
- Successfully communicating with Thalassa: 750 XP per character
- Gaining Nereon's approval: 1,000 XP per character
- Successfully closing the planar rift: 2,000 XP per character

Exploration Rewards:

- Finding and understanding each level's purpose: 250 XP per character per level
- Discovering all research notes: 500 XP per character

Appendices

Appendix A: Random Underwater Encounters

For travel between areas or extended exploration:

d6 Roll | Encounter

1. School of aggressive fish (treat as swarm of quippers)
2. Territorial sea turtle (giant turtle, non-hostile unless provoked)
3. Kelp forest (difficult terrain, hiding predators)
4. Underwater thermal vent (provides warmth but deals fire damage if touched)
5. Sunken debris (possible treasure, possible trap)
6. Echo of the past (ghostly vision of the keep before the disaster)

Appendix B: Spell Modifications Underwater

Fire Spells: Deal no damage unless magical in nature **Lightning Spells:** Affect all creatures within 5 feet of target **Ice/Cold Spells:** Function normally but may create temporary barriers

Verbal Components: Require air bubble or water breathing to function **Somatic Components:** May have disadvantage while swimming

Appendix C: Scaling the Adventure

For Lower Level Parties (1st-2nd level):

- Reduce monster hit points by 25%
- Remove some encounters from each room
- Provide additional water breathing resources

For Higher Level Parties (6th+ level):

- Add additional monsters to encounters
- Include more powerful variants (e.g., reef sharks become hunter sharks)
- Add environmental complications (stronger currents, deeper pressures)

Appendix D: Continuing the Campaign

If the Rift is Closed:

- The party becomes heroes of Saltmarsh
- Potential employment by coastal cities for similar problems
- Access to Order archives opens new adventure possibilities

If the Rift Remains Open:

- Escalating consequences as the rift grows
- New elemental creatures threaten the region
- Political ramifications as refugees flee coastal areas

New Adventure Hooks:

- Other Order strongholds may exist with similar problems
- Elemental lords seek revenge for closing their potential foothold

- Scholars want to study the party's methods for future rift closures
 - The Order's enemies may have been behind the original sabotage
-

Designer's Notes

This adventure emphasizes resource management and environmental challenges over pure combat. The underwater setting creates unique tactical considerations that force players to think creatively about movement, spellcasting, and survival.

The central mystery provides multiple solution paths - parties might negotiate with the surviving Order members, discover the truth through research, or simply fight their way to the rift. The key NPCs (Marina, Thalassa, and Nereon) represent different aspects of the Order's legacy and can serve as allies, enemies, or complex moral challenges depending on the party's approach.

The treasure is front-loaded in the deeper levels to reward thorough exploration and provide the tools necessary for the final encounter. The Pearls of Planar Binding create a clear objective while the research notes provide the knowledge needed to use them effectively.

Estimated Play Time: 4-6 sessions of 4-5 hours each **Party Composition:** Works best with at least one character capable of providing water breathing (druid, cleric, wizard, or warlock)

Difficulty: Moderate to challenging, with emphasis on problem-solving over combat optimization

End of Adventure